MONTHLY UPDATE

Botswana: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16-3 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.

STATUS · PROGRESS · INSTITUTION HOSTING

GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · TECHNOLOGY · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Strategies, plans and policies

NATIONAL DATA STRATEGY

- **Botswana concludes capacity building and stakeholder engagement for national data strategy** — Digital Watch Observatory, 14 September 2026

  Botswana's Ministry of Communications and Innovation held a five-day data governance training and stakeholder workshop from 7 to 11 September 2026 to develop a National Data Strategy from its earlier National Data Policy. The work is backed by the African Union Commission and the European Union under the Data Governance in Africa Initiative, with AUDA-NEPAD and GIZ providing implementation support. No budget is given.

SMARTBOTS DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION STRATEGY

- **Govt targets UNEP to build smart economy** — DailyNews (Botswana Press Agency), 23 September 2026

  Botswana's President Duma Boko told UN Economic Commission for Africa head Claver Gatete in New York that the SmartBots digital transformation strategy will be formally launched in November 2026. Boko asked the commission to remain a partner in it as a flagship project. The meeting date is not stated.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity · Data Storage · Energy

Connectivity

BOFINET INTERNATIONAL CAPACITY LEASE THROUGH SOUTH AFRICA

- **BoFiNet upgrades its available international capacity to 1 Tbit/s** — Connecting Africa, 23 September 2026

  Botswana Fibre Networks signed a long-term international capacity lease with an unnamed South African partner, raising capacity through the Ramatlabama and Pioneer Gate border crossings from 300 Gbit/s to 1 Tbit/s.

DIGITAL DELTA IX

- **BoFiNet launches Digital Delta IXP** — ITWeb Africa, 6 October 2026

Botswana's state fibre operator BoFiNet announced the launch of the Digital Delta Internet Exchange Point, where service providers, mobile operators and content and cloud providers can exchange local traffic inside the country. It builds on the operator's Tier III-certified data centre.

UNIVERSAL FUND BROADBAND EXPANSION ALONG THE TRANS-KALAHARI HIGHWAY

- **Botswana invests in highway connectivity** — ITWeb Africa, 12 October 2026

  Botswana's universal service fund, working with one mobile operator, has deployed 12 mobile broadband and voice sites along the 1,900km Trans-Kalahari Highway at a cost of P34.5 million, the communications minister said. Infrastructure sharing with the other two operators is to extend coverage by the end of the next financial year.

Data Storage

KALA DATA CENTRE

- **Tlou weighs Kala data centre expansion** — ITWeb Africa, 5 October 2026

  Tlou Energy's annual report says Botswana's gas-powered Kala Data Centre ran well below its design of about 1MW in the year to June 2026, for lack of gas from the one connected well. The company has begun planning a pipeline from a second well, and any expansion depends on gas supply and funding.

Energy

ELECTRICITY TARIFF APPLICATION 2026-27

- **BPC 2026-27 Electricity Tariff Application — Consultation Paper** — Botswana Energy Regulatory Authority (BERA), 15 December 2025

  Botswana Power Corporation's tariff application for 2026/27, published by the Botswana Energy Regulatory Authority on 15 December 2025, sets a revenue requirement of P9.585 billion against current revenues of P6.108 billion excluding government subsidy, a gap of P3.477 billion. The utility proposes a tariff increase from 1 April 2026 and still projects a P397 million net loss.

KALA HYBRID GAS AND SOLAR GENERATION

- **Tlou weighs Kala data centre expansion** — ITWeb Africa, 5 October 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

DPI

Data Exchange · Digital Payments and Fintech · Other GovTech and e-Gov

Data Exchange

NATIONAL ELECTRONIC KNOW-YOUR-CUSTOMER PROJECT

- **Botswana launches national eKYC project to make bank verification easier** — Business Tech Africa, 11 September 2026

  The Bankers' Association of Botswana has launched a national electronic know-your-customer project letting banks check customer identities against the national citizen database instead of certified photocopies of identity cards. The report notes the association launched a similar eKYC system in 2021. No launch date is given.

Digital Payments and Fintech

FNBB EWALLET TRANSFERS INTO MOBILE-MONEY WALLETS

- **FNBB muscles into mobile money race** — Mmegi, 14 September 2026

  First National Bank Botswana will let customers receiving money through its eWallet service transfer it directly to Orange Money, Mascom's MyZaka and BTC's Smega. The bank announced the plan with results for the year to June 2026, showing profit before tax up 12 per cent to P2.12 billion. No launch date is given.

GOOGLE PAY ON ABSA BANK BOTSWANA CARDS

- **Absa Botswana's Google Pay, Bringing contactless payments to a nation still reaching for them** — Weekend Post, 21 September 2026

  Absa Bank Botswana has made Google Pay available on Android for its Visa debit, credit and multi-currency virtual cards, with no extra fees. The launch date was not given. The service only works where merchants have NFC terminals, and the report says these are patchy outside Gaborone and Francistown.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

ROAD TRANSPORT AND SAFETY LICENSING SYSTEMS

- **The system is down, not the road traffic act** — Sunday Standard, 5 October 2026

  Botswana's Ministry of Transport and Infrastructure announced interim manual measures on 29 September 2026 after a government systems outage at the Department of Road Transport and Safety. Expired transport permits are extended by hand with an official stamp, and vehicles with expired roadworthiness certificates are tested and given manual receipts, which police will accept until systems are restored.

Technology

AI

AI

AI CLINICAL DECISION SUPPORT THROUGH THE BOTSWANA-UPENN PARTNERSHIP

- **OpenEvidence and Penn Medicine partner to extend AI clinical decision support to Botswana** — YourBotswana, 18 September 2026

  OpenEvidence and Penn Medicine announced on 15 September 2026 a partnership to deploy OpenEvidence's AI clinical decision-support platform to Penn's clinicians and to extend it to Botswana through the Botswana-UPenn Partnership. A customised set of tools is to be built with the partnership's clinicians. No timetable, site count or cost for Botswana is given.

Data

National statistics

National statistics

GAMBLING PARTICIPATION STATISTICS

- **Weaving the Slip** — Botswana Gazette, 2 September 2026

  A Botswana Gazette investigation published on 2 September 2026 reports that Botswana keeps no gambling statistics as it moves to lower the legal betting age. Unregistered betting influencers draw 4,000 to 15,000 responses to a single slip and refer followers to bookmakers, while parents in Mathethe and Digawana describe children funding bets from household mobile-money and bank accounts.

Geopolitics

China activities

China activities

CHINA-BOTSWANA COMPREHENSIVE STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP JOINT STATEMENT

- 中华人民共和国和博茨瓦纳共和国关于建立全面战略合作伙伴关系的联合声明 — Embassy of the People's Republic of China in Tanzania (republishing the China-Botswana joint statement), 13 October 2026

  China and Botswana raised relations to a comprehensive strategic partnership in a joint statement issued during President Duma Boko's state visit. It affirms digital sovereignty and each state's right to choose its own path on artificial intelligence; Botswana joins China's digital economy trade-cooperation initiative and will consider joining the World AI Cooperation Organization.

HUAWEI COOPERATION AGREEMENT ON DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

- **Huawei critical partner in digital transformation** — Botswana Daily News (BOPA), 14 October 2026

  Botswana signed a cooperation agreement on digital transformation with Huawei at the company's Beijing Research Institute on 13 October 2026, during President Duma Boko's state visit to China. It covers cloud hosting of government data, smart education, telemedicine and AI-powered public security for the police. No value is stated.

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